



Sightseeing & tours brief information

1. Temple of Karnak



Of all Luxor's many monuments, the Temple Complex of Karnak has to be its most astonishing and beautiful feat. Within its precincts are the **Great Temple of Amun**, the **Temple of Khons**, and the **Festival Temple of Tuthmosis III**, as well as many other buildings. It is not built to a single unified plan but represents the building activity of many successive rulers of Egypt, who vied with one another in adding to and adorning this great national sanctuary, which became the most important of Egypt's temples during the New Kingdom.

All the monuments here are on a gigantic scale, reducing visitors to ant-like proportions as they gaze up at mighty columns and colossal statuary.



2. Valley of the Kings



The famed Valley of the Kings, hidden between rocky escarpments, was the final resting place for the kings of the 18th, 19th, and 20th dynasties. Their main attraction is their wonderfully vivid wall paintings. Since it was believed that the dead man, accompanied by the sun god (or perhaps having become one with the sun god) sailed through the underworld at night in a boat, the walls of the tombs were adorned with texts and scenes depicting this voyage and giving the dead man instruction on its course.

Within the valley are 63 tombs, which are a roll-call of famous names of Egyptian history, including the famous boy-king **Tutankhamun**. The tombs are open on a rotation system to preserve the paintings as much as possible from the damage caused by humidity.



3. Temple of Deir al-Bahri (Queen Hatshepsut's Temple)



The **Temple of Deir el-Bahri** is magnificently situated at the foot of the sheer cliffs fringing the desert hills, the light-colored, almost white, sandstone of the temple standing out prominently against the golden yellow to light brown rocks behind. The temple complex is laid out on three terraces rising from the plain, linked by ramps, which divide it into a northern and a southern half. Along the west side of each terrace is a raised colonnade.

The terraces were hewn out of the eastern slopes of the hills, with retaining walls of the finest sandstone along the sides and to the rear. The temple itself was also partly hewn from the rock. Inside, the complex is richly adorned with statues, reliefs, and inscriptions. Note how Queen Hatshepsut had herself represented with the attributes of a male pharaoh (beard and short apron) to demonstrate that she possessed all the authority of a king.



4. Medinet Habu



Medinet Habu hieroglyphs

With the famous Valley of the Kings and Temple of Deir al-Bahri the main attractions, **Medinet Habu** often gets overlooked on a West Bank trip, but this is one of Egypt's most beautifully decorated temples and should be on everyone's West Bank hit list. The complex consists of a small, older temple built during the 18th dynasty and enlarged in the Late Period, and the great Temple of Ramses III, associated with a royal palace, which was surrounded by a battlemented enclosure wall four meters high.

The main temple area was built exactly on the model of the Ramesseum and, like the Ramesseum, was dedicated to Amun. The reliefs here are some of the best you'll see on the West Bank.



5. Colossi of Memnon



Beside the road that runs from the **Valley of the Queens** and **Medinet Habu** towards the Nile are the famous gigantic statues known as the **Colossi of Memnon**. Carved out of hard yellowish-brown sandstone quarried in the hills above Edfu, they represent Amenophis III seated on a cube-shaped throne, and once stood guard at the entrance to the king's temple, of which only scanty traces are left. In Roman Imperial times they were taken for statues of Memnon, son of Eos and Tithonus, who was killed by Achilles during the Trojan War.

The **South Colossus** is better preserved than the one to the north. It stands 19.59-meters high and the base is partly buried under the sand. With the crown that it originally wore but has long since vanished, the total height must have been some 21 meters.

The **North Colossus** is the famous "musical statue," which brought flocks of visitors here during the Roman Imperial period. Visitors observed that the statue emitted a musical note at sunrise and this gave rise to the myth that Memnon was greeting his mother, Eos, with this soft, plaintive note. The sound ceased to be heard after Emperor Septimus Severus had the upper part of the statue restored.



6. Luxor Temple



Presiding over the modern downtown district, Luxor Temple is an ode to the changing face of Egypt through the centuries. Built first by Amenophis III (on the site of an earlier sandstone temple), it was known as "the southern harem of Amun" and was dedicated to Amun, his consort Mut, and their son the moon god Khons. Like all Egyptian temples, it comprises the chapels of the deities with their vestibules and subsidiary chambers, a large **Hypostyle Hall**, and an open **Peristyle Court**, which was approached from the north by a great colonnade.

The temple was added to and changed by a parade of pharaohs, including Amenophis IV (who obliterated all references to the god Amun within the temple and added the Sanctuary of the god Aten), Tutankhamun (who had the walls of the colonnade embellished with reliefs and in turn destroyed the Temple of the Aten), Seti I (who restored the reliefs of Amun), and Ramses II (who extended the temple significantly, adding a new colonnaded court at the north end). During the Christian era, the temple underwent a transformation into a church, while in the Islamic period, the **Mosque of Abu el-Haggag**, dedicated to a revered holy man, was built inside the complex grounds.



7. Temple of Hathor at Dendera



Although Dendera Temple lacks the magnificence of earlier temples like those of Abydos and Karnak, it impresses with its fine proportions and dignified adaptation to its purpose. The profusion of reliefs and inscriptions on the walls are excellent examples of the Egyptian decorative art of the Late Period. Dendera itself was once capital of Upper Egypt, and the scant remnants of this once great town lie on the west bank of the Nile across from the modern town of Qena.

Location: 76 kilometers north of Luxor



8- Temples of Abydos



Temples of Abydos

The grand **necropolis complex** of Abydos is one of the oldest necropolises in Egypt and is associated with the first Egyptian capital of Thinis. It was here that kings and high court dignitaries were buried during the 1st and 2nd dynasties, and the rituals of kingly burials were first celebrated to symbolize the transitory and recurrent character of all earthly things. The site is centered round the beautiful Temple of Seti I and is a fine day out from Luxor.

Location: 162 kilometers north of Luxor



9. Temple of Khnum, Esna (Not included in the program)



In the center of Esna, freed from the rubble of later centuries and now nine meters below the present street level, is the Temple of Khnum, the ram-headed local god, and his associate goddesses Neith and Satet. The outer walls bear reliefs and inscriptions by Roman Emperors. On the south side, Domitian is depicted smiting his enemies in the presence of Khnum and Menheyet, and on the north side, Khnum, with the goddess Nebtu standing behind him, presents Trajan, also shown smiting his enemies, with the sickle sword. The seven-aisled **Vestibule** was the only part of the temple that was completed and dates almost entirely from the Roman Imperial period.

Location: 56 kilometers south of Luxor



10. Temple of Horus at Edfu



The 2,000-year-old Temple of Horus is almost perfectly preserved, and the history of its construction and a description of the entire structure are set forth in long inscriptions on the outside of the enclosure wall, particularly at the north end of the east and west sides. Construction began in 237 BC, in the reign of Ptolemy III Euergetes I, and was completed in 212 under his successor, Philopator. Its relative youth, compared to the temples in Luxor, means that it is in much better shape than other temples and remains one of the best places in Egypt to really imagine the grandeur of ancient Egypt.

Location: 110 kilometers south of Luxor



11, Gebel Silsila



Gebel Silsila is the name given to a rocky gorge between Kom Ombo and Edfu where the River Nile narrows and high sandstone cliffs come right down to the water's edge. There was probably a series of rapids here in ancient times, dangerous to navigate, which naturally formed a frontier between the regions of Elephantine (Aswan) and Edfu. In Pharaonic times the river here was known as Khennui, the 'place of rowing'. On the West bank there is a tall column of rock which has been dubbed 'The Capstan' because of a local legend which claims there was once a chain (*Silsila* in Arabic) which ran from the East to the West Banks. Arthur Weigall in his 'Antiquities of Egypt' states that the name *Silsileh*, is a Roman corruption of the original Egyptian name for the town, *Khol-Khol*, meaning a barrier or frontier.



12. Kom Ombo Temple



The Kom Ombo Temple, twin-dedicated to the deities Sobek and Haroeris, was built to a unified plan, which in effect accommodated two temples in a single building. The temple was also embellished with **reliefs** by Philometor, Euergetes II, and Neos Dionysos. One of the finest Ptolemaic temples in Egypt, its lavish decoration harks back to a time when Kom Ombo's position beside the Nile made it one of Upper Egypt's most important centers of trade and commerce.

Location: 168 kilometers south of Luxor



13. Temple of Kalabsha



Walk along an imposing stone causeway that leads from the banks of the lake to the first pylon of the temple, pass a colonnaded court and into the eight columned hypostyle hall. Note the hieroglyphs and the reliefs of Greek pharaohs paying homage to Ancient Egyptian deities. Look for Mandulis, the god clad in the vulture feathered cloak. Built during the late Ptolemaic period and completed during the reign of the Roman emperor Augustus, the Temple of Kalabsha was dedicated to the Nubian god called Mandulis.



14. Temple of Isis (Philae Temple)



Built to honour the goddess Isis, this was the last temple built in the classical Egyptian style. Construction began around 690 BC, and it was one of the last outposts where the goddess was worshipped. The cult of Isis continued here until at least AD 550. The boat leaves you near the Kiosk of Nectanebo, the oldest part, and the entrance to the temple is marked by the 18m-high first pylon with reliefs of Ptolemy XII Neos Dionysos smiting enemies.

In the central court of the Temple of Isis, the *mammisi* (birth house) is dedicated to Horus, son of Isis and Osiris. Successive pharaohs reinstated their legitimacy as the mortal descendants of Horus by taking part in rituals celebrating the Isis legend and the birth of her son Horus in the marshes. The second pylon leads to a hypostyle hall, with superb column capitals. Note also the reuse of the temple as a Christian church, with crosses carved into the older hieroglyph reliefs, and images of the Egyptian gods carefully defaced. Beyond lie three vestibules, leading into the **Inner Sanctuary of Isis**. Two



granite shrines stood here, one containing a gold statue of Isis and another containing the *barque* in which the statue travelled, but these were long ago moved to Florence and Paris, and only the stone pedestal for the *barque* remains, inscribed with the names of Ptolemy III and his wife, Berenice. Take a side door west out of the hypostyle hall to the **Gate of Hadrian** where there is an image of the god Hapi, sitting in a cave at the First Cataract, representing the source of the river Nile.

East of the second pylon is the delightful **Temple of Hathor**, decorated with reliefs of musicians (including an ape playing the lute) and Bes, the god of childbirth. South of this is the elegant, unfinished pavilion by the water's edge, known as the **Kiosk of Trajan** ('Pharaoh's Bed'), perhaps the most famous of Philae's monuments and one that was frequently painted by Victorian artists, whose boats were moored beneath it.

The whole complex was moved from its original location on Philae Island, to its new location on Agilkia Island, after the flooding of Lake Nasser. A major multinational Unesco team relocated Philae, and a number of other temples that now dot the shores of Lake Nasser. You can see the submerged original island a short distance away, punctuated by the steel columns used in the moving process.

Don't miss the sound and light show at night, the least cheesy of the sound and light 'extravaganzas'. On your feet, look out for the extremely creative guards who will do all in their power to get in your photos, or to point out the hieroglyphs that you can quite clearly see yourself, all for some baksheesh (tip)!



15.Abu-Simbel Temples



Prepare to be blown away by the magnificence of these temples. They are undisputedly one of the world's most breathtaking monuments, and Egypt's second most visited touristic site, the Pyramids of Giza being on the top of the list. The relocation of the temples was a historic event in the 1960's. At that time, the temples were threatened by submersion in Lake Nasser when the High Dam was constructed. The Egyptian government with the support of UNESCO launched a worldwide appeal to save these colossal landmarks. They were successfully dismantled and relocated to a spot 60 meters above the cliff where they had been initially built. The more famous of the two temples is dedicated to Ramses II and the smaller one to his favourite wife Nefertari. They were both built by Ramses II in the 13th century BC. The gigantic facade of Ramses II temple represents four colossal seated figures of Ramses. The facade is 119 feet wide, 100 feet high, and the statues are each 67 feet high. The facade door leads to the interior of the temple is a 185 feet long man-made rock cave that leads to a series of halls and rooms. The most



remarkable feature of the temple of Abu-Simbel is that the construction is oriented in a way that twice a year, the morning sun rays shine through the length of the inner temple cave and illuminate the statues of the four gods seated at the end of the cave.

Dahabeya's Cruise Route

